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INTEROPERABILITY INDEX

Cross-Border Payments in the Americas



Table of Contents

1. CROSS-BORDER PAYMENTS IN THE AMERICAS 03

1.1 Introduction 04

1.2 Ranking 05

1.3 Ranking Deep Dive 06

1.4 Key Takeaways 08

1.4.1 Digital Infrastructure 12

1.4.2 Financial Inclusion 14

1.4.3 Cross-Border Connectivity 17

1.4.4 Market Dynamics and Progress 21

1.4.5 Payment Provider Preferences 25

1.4.6 Conclusion 28

2. THE INTEROPERABILITY INDEX FULL VERSION 29

3. APPENDIX 33

4. ABOUT THUNES 37

Cross-Border Payments in the Americas

1

1.1 Introduction: Interoperability in the Payments Landscape of the Americas

Interoperability is a critical factor in determining how effectively individuals, businesses, and financial institutions can participate in an increasingly globalised digital economy. This is represented through the Thunes Cross-Border Interoperability Index, which operationalises the ability individuals have to transact with businesses, and transfer money outside of their national systems.

Interoperability is often viewed solely through a technical lens, where the focus is on whether systems can exchange information and process transactions. In practice, it encompasses a broader set of more holistic considerations. Effective interoperability determines whether consumers can access services regardless of their preferred payment method and whether business can reach customers across borders without added complexity. Finally, the ability to integrate new payments innovations into existing financial infrastructure without creating unnecessary costs and friction is a key factor when building interoperability.

Achieving contextual interoperability involves curating an approach that adapts to the cultural and infrastructural realities of each market. In the US, this entails recognising the significant fragmentation around payment preferences in the international payments market. Many major global payment processors and digital wallets are based in the US, as well as fintech innovators such as BNPL and cryptocurrency services, which opens up significant choice for users. Taking this into consideration when building interoperability is vital to expanding access to fast, low-cost international payments delivered to the recipient's account or wallet of choice.

Latin America and the Caribbean have historically had trouble making international payments through the traditional method of correspondent banking due to the practice of 'de-risking', which is when major international banks terminate their relationships with banks in countries considered at high risk for money laundering. Fees may also be hiked to cover the cost of KYC and AML checks for international payments; complicating the process for those sending money to or from Latin America. As a result, this region has been partially isolated from the global payments' community, with those seeking to remit money or pay businesses internationally facing complications.



1.2 Ranking

Country	Regional rank	Global rank	Overall score
US	1	21	6.5
Canada	2	22	6.4
Brazil	3	24	6
Mexico	4	33	4.6
Chile	5	34	4.4
Argentina	6	39	3.9
Colombia	7	45	3.4
Peru	8	56	3.2

The US, Canada, Brazil, and Mexico rank just above the middle of all 50 countries in the interoperability index, whilst the other Latin American countries are spread throughout the bottom half. This is because as a region, Latin America remains fairly siloed from others, as Latin America is not a significant sender or receiver of remittances or B2B payments on the global stage. This lack of cross-border flows disincentivises investment into streamlining payment system corridors. In comparison, the US and Canada both process a large volume of cross-border B2B and personal flows to and from their countries, meaning their corridors are often prioritised by international payments providers.

The US and Canada rank highly for economic health, digital infrastructure and financial inclusion, but have stalled in terms of keeping up with implementing new technologies, particularly real-time payments and A2A payments. On the other hand, Brazil and Mexico score highly in payments innovations, but have yet to widely expand this progress into interoperability within the cross-border space.

1.3 Ranking Deep Dive

#	Country	Economic Health	Digital Infra-structure	Financial Inclusion	Cross-Border Connectivity	Market Dynamics & Progress	Overall Score
1	US	6.8	7.5	6.6	5.9	5.0	***6.5***
2	Canada	7.5	7.0	6.7	6.3	4.0	***6.4***
3	Brazil	2.5	6.0	6.4	3.6	10.0	***6.0***
4	Mexico	4.0	3.3	5.7	2.6	7.5	***4.6***
5	Chile	4.8	4.3	4.4	3.0	6.0	***4.4***
6	Argentina	3.3	3.8	4.5	3.0	4.5	***3.9***
7	Colombia	3.3	3.0	3.5	2.6	5.0	***3.4***
8	Peru	4.5	1.8	3.8	3.0	4.0	***3.2***

The Thunes Cross-Border Payments Interoperability Index evaluates 50 countries across five key dimensions of interoperability: the macroeconomic environment, population-level access to digital infrastructure, financial inclusion, cross-border connectivity and market dynamics. Overall, this produces a score that takes each element into account.

Digital infrastructure creates the foundation for achieving interoperability. A reliable, accessible layer of digital infrastructure such as affordable internet connectivity is a key prerequisite for rolling out digital payment methods. This metric acts as a proxy for the readiness of the market for undertaking interoperability initiatives; if a country has a strong digital infrastructure score but lacks on other metrics, it is likely ready for interoperability investment.

The financial inclusion metric is designed to assess the extent to which all segments of society can access formal financial infrastructure and fast payments, as well as the quality of access. This includes metrics such as the percentage of the population that has either a bank account or mobile money account, thus considering alternative methods of financial inclusion.

The cross-border connectivity score indicates the cost, speed, and frequency of cross-border payments outbound from a country. A high value of cross-border payments per

capita indicates strong direct banking relationships, as countries tend to establish direct banking relationships with their major trading partners. In turn, this reduces the cost and speed of making a payment via a bank.

Market dynamics and progress operationalise the openness to payments innovation by looking at the status of cryptocurrency regulation, open banking mandates, and government-led initiatives for cross-border payments. This is important for visualising the future of interoperability in a country.



1.4 Key Takeaways

Youth Leading Digital Banking Wave in Brazil

In Brazil, a strong swing towards digital banking has occurred for savings, daily transactions, and cross-border payments. This partly arises from the unique banking landscape of Brazil; five big banks used to control 80% of the market, leading to high fees for account maintenance for the average customer and a large population which were underbanked. As a result, when digital-first neobanks entered with products such as low or no-fee accounts designed to appeal to the underbanked, uptake was huge amongst that group. Currently, 62% of Brazilian adults are customers of Brazil's biggest neobank: Nubank[1]; an impressive feat given their launch was only 13 years ago.

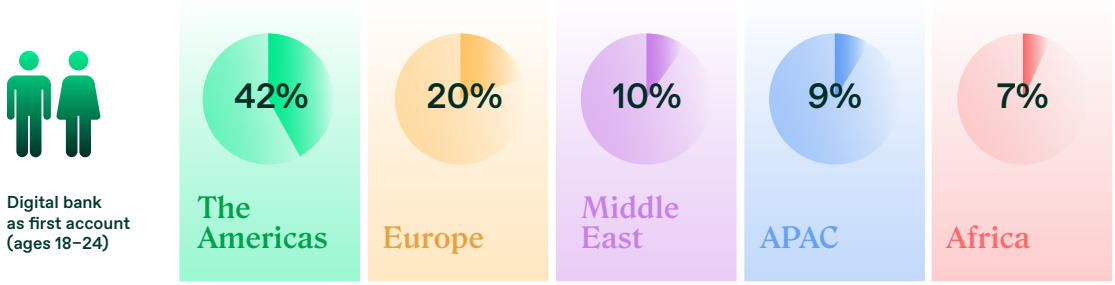
This preference translates into international payments, where digital banking outperforming traditional banks; 35% of Brazilians use digital banks to send international payments, compared to 27% using traditional banks. This displacement of traditional banking is likely to intensify over time, given that preference for digital banking is stronger in the youth. The digital banking wave is being led by Gen Z, who are highly engaged with mobile-first banking. Digital banks are gaining ground as the first point of contact with the formal financial system, which frames their expectations for banking going forward.

61% of 18–24-year-olds in Brazil opened a digital bank account as their first formal financial account



This was the highest proportion amongst all the surveyed countries and regions; suggesting that the digital fintech market in Brazil is thriving amongst the youth. For international payment providers to appeal to this bracket, they must prioritise integrating with digital bank accounts as endpoints for payments. Linking just to the main traditional banks in a country is not sufficient to appeal to the younger generations.

Figure 1.1: The proportion of 18–24-year-olds who opened a digital bank account as their first formal financial account, by region

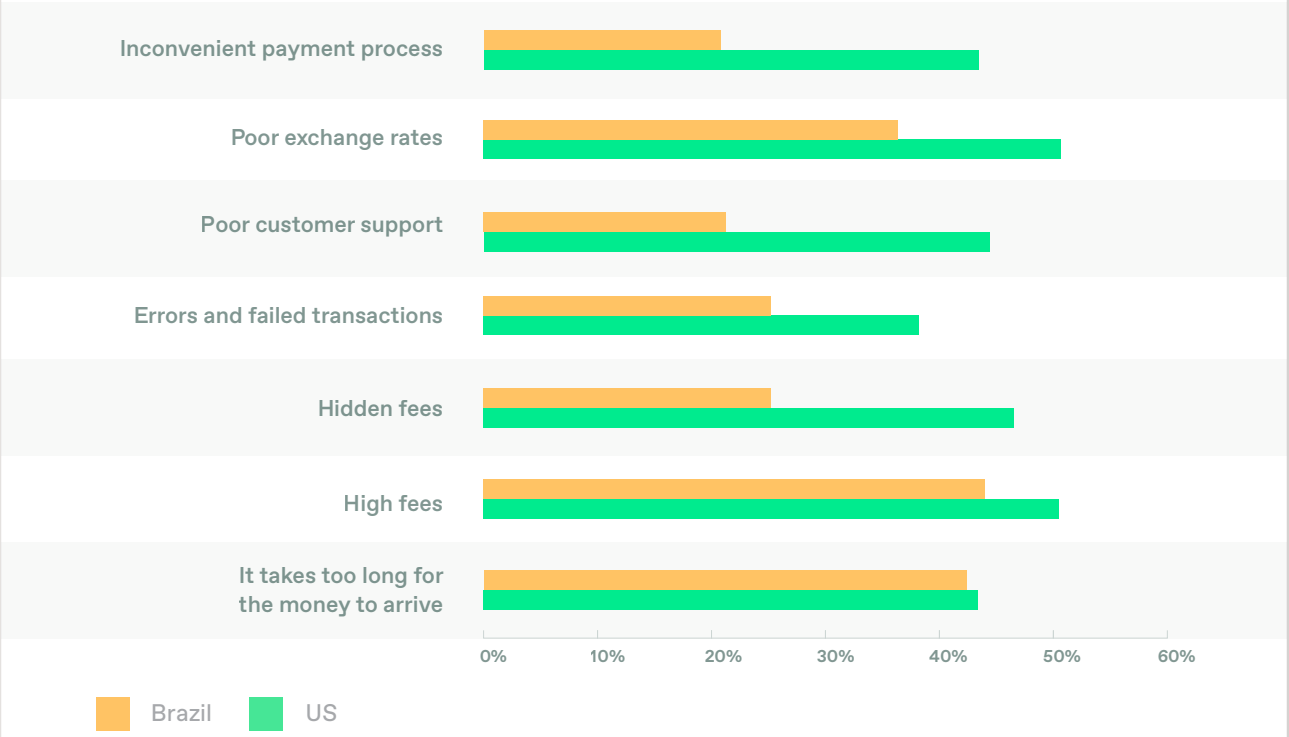


[1] Nu: About Us — Nubank

Expectations Gap: The US Reports High Dissatisfaction with Cross-Border Payments Experiences

Dissatisfaction in the US regarding cross-border payments is high across multiple categories. For example, those sending money internationally in the US are the most likely of all the surveyed countries to report experiencing hidden fees and poor customer service. This lines up with the lack of transparency reported by users: 51% of Americans sending money internationally were not always shown the final amount that will be received upfront, compared to a global average of 41% globally and 36% in Brazil. This suggests international payment service providers in the US should improve their standard of transparency so that their users can make informed decisions about their money transfers.

Figure 1.2: % of issues experienced sometimes, often, or very often by those sending international payments



Disproportionate levels of dissatisfaction were also reported amongst issues such as ‘high fees’ and ‘the money takes too long to arrive’. However, a discrepancy appears when looking at objective measures: transfer times and fees paid are slightly under the global average, which suggests there is an expectations gap present. Users in the US have high expectations and are easily dissatisfied; suggesting that payment service providers operating in the USA need to be aware of user’s high standards.

CASE STUDY

American Gig Worker

Lives in the USA · Lives in an suburban area · 25–34 years old

HER INCOME

- She earns **$2,000–$4,000 a month**, the majority of which is from gig work ($1,500–$3,000 a month).
- **She lives paycheck to paycheck**, with little to no money left over at the end of the month, and depends on financial support from family to meet her regular expenses.
- **Her first formal financial account was a mobile wallet**, which she opened at the age of 25–30 because it was the lowest cost option available.

Her Challenges

She "often" experiences inconvenient payment processes when receiving international payments.

Delays, fees, and uncertainty in international payments have caused her to "lose or turn down job opportunities" and "increased stress or anxiety".

When sending international payments, she often experiences:

- Errors & failed transactions
- Poor customer support
- Poor exchange rates



INTERNATIONAL PAYMENTS

- She receives international salary payments from an employer abroad once every two months.
- These payments are $500–$1,000, and the fees paid are between 3–5%.
- She receives these payments in a mobile wallet.
- She also sends $200–$500 quarterly to other North American countries for services provided by someone overseas and for personal transfer to make payments in another country.
- She sends this via a mobile wallet, paying 3–5% in fees each time.

Her Priorities

Her top priorities in a payments provider are:

- Low fees
- Transparent fees
- Security

CONCLUSION

She continues to use a mobile wallet to make and receive international payments, which is the first type of financial account she opened and therefore a familiar mechanism.

However, her salary payments take **2–3 days** to arrive, which can cause knock-on effects like losing or turning down job opportunities.

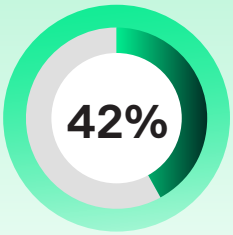
Brazil Faces Longest Delays in Cross-Border Payment

Globally, most people receive their international payments within a day, with 27% taking two or more days to receive their payment. In Brazil, this jumps to 42%; indicating significant waits are in place. This could point to the difficulties with going through the correspondent banking system, as the most common method of funding a cross-border payment in Brazil is with a bank transfer, which 45% of cross-border payments senders typically use.

The impact of these wait times is underscored by the importance that those in Brazil place on fast cross-border transfers. Half of Brazilians (51%) stated that quick transfers were their most valued feature in an international payments' provider. Those offering instant transfers will therefore have a strong competitive advantage.

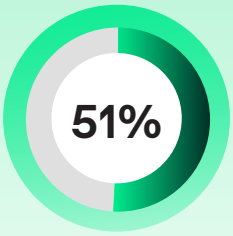
Brazil also experiences considerably higher costs than other countries; being the second most expensive in the G20 to remit from, second only to South Africa. The cost of sending a payment from Brazil was recorded at 11.9% by the World Bank in Q3 2025[2], which has risen considerably over time. Those remitting from Brazil face high correspondent fees, exchange rate mark-ups, and the foreign exchange tax. Improving the experiences of those sending money through Latin American corridors should be a priority. Integrating directly into commonly used real-time rails such as PIX in Brazil or Yape mobile accounts in Peru could drive progress towards lowering costs and improving speed.

When receiving a cross-border payment,



of those in Brazil reports waits of over 2 days

In Brazil,



said "quick transfers" were the most valuable feature in an internatioanl payments provider



[2] Remittance Prices Worldwide — World Bank

1.4.1 Digital Infrastructure

Country	Digital Infra-structure
US	7.5
Canada	7.0
Brazil	6.0
Chile	4.3
Argentina	3.8
Mexico	3.3
Colombia	3.0
Peru	1.8

Digital infrastructure describes the level of access to and participation in digital payments across a population. At a national level, countries must have several infrastructural factors firmly in place before the digital economy can thrive; widespread Internet connectivity, high smartphone ownership, and affordable mobile subscriptions and internet access. Once this is in place, usage of digital payment systems can begin to proliferate across the population.

In the Interoperability Index, the Digital Infrastructure score measures this through the following metrics:

- Internet Usage (%)
- Smartphone Ownership (%)
- Digital Payments Activity in the past 3 months (%)
- Mobile Wallet Ownership (%)

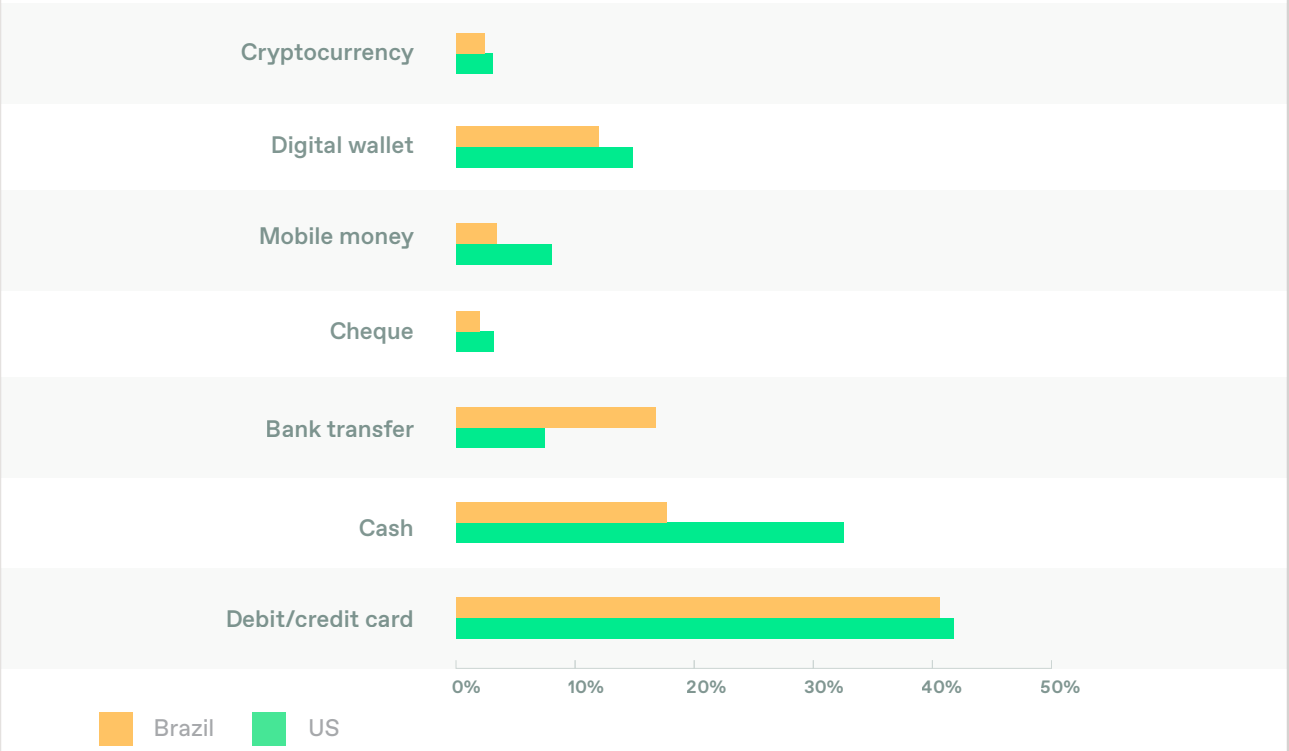
Internet access and broadband coverage is high across North America; driving high digital infrastructure scores in the US and Canada, but remains patchy in rural areas across Latin America, where a significant digital divide exists between those who live in urban and rural areas. Measures are being implemented to address this, such as Internet Para Todos (Internet for All) in Peru, which selected a low-orbit satellite Internet service to connect stations in remote locations in Peru; helping to deliver 4G mobile service to people in rural areas. As such, digitalisation is expected to improve rapidly across Latin America, laying the foundations for digital payments.

Working groups have been created to encourage interoperability within digital public infrastructure, such as IDB Group that created IDB Pay, which supports countries building inclusive, interoperable, and secure fast-payment infrastructure. It has already provided technical assistance for Bre-B, Colombia's instant payment system; signalling that the region is moving away from simply growing digital access and towards strengthening digital financial resilience.

Digital Payments Method Usage

The use of digital payments varies considerably across the Americas. Cash remains the sole preference for vast swathes of the population across Latin America, although cards have penetrated into common daily use across Brazil, Mexico, and Uruguay. The USA also retains a significant proportion of cash users within the population, although as seen in the below figure, it is common for other digital payment methods to be used alongside cash.

Figure 1.3: Prevalence of Payment Methods Used Daily (% of population, multiple choice)



A2A Payments Prevail in Brazil but Lag in the US

Brazil reports one of the highest usage of bank transfers across all surveyed countries, second only to India; 59% of those in Brazil use bank transfers daily or weekly. The success of A2A payments can be attributed to PIX, which is a real-time payment system created by the Central Bank of Brazil in 2020. It is required to be offered by every financial institution in the country, and allows users to transfer money directly between bank accounts using PIX keys, or scanning QR codes at the point of checkout. It has been a considerable success, and the ability to accept PIX payments has also been rolled out to merchants in Portugal, Spain, Uruguay, Peru and Paraguay.

In comparison, the roll out of FedNow - the instant payment system of the US - has had a slower uptake. While most other countries with widespread instant payment

schemes have scaled through regulations that mandate adoption, the absence of this in the US has led to fragmented adoption. The US also lacks an accessible A2A user interface such as the one Brazil has, where all that users need to transact is a PIX key which is recognised nationally. The lack of a similar system in the US means that third-party apps such as Zelle, Cashapp, and PayPal have gained prominence instead of a centralised real-time payment system. However, some of these charge extra fees for instant transfers. For example, CashApp is free for standard transfers to a bank account that take one to three days, but charges 0.5%-2.5% for instant deposits. This limits the accessibility of instant payments for US users.

1.4.2 Financial Inclusion

Country	Financial Inclusion
Canada	6.7
US	6.6
Brazil	6.4
Mexico	5.7
Argentina	4.5
Chile	4.4
Peru	3.8
Colombia	3.5

Financial inclusion is the process of ensuring that everybody can access financial services equally and can easily make payments using a trusted payments system regardless of age, gender, or geography.

This comprised of the following metrics in the interoperability index:

Access to bank branches: This metric reflects the availability of physical banking infrastructure per 1,000 in the population. While digital-first banks are becoming more prevalent, access to in-person services remains essential, particularly for individuals who are digitally excluded or rely on cash and face-to-face support.

Wealth inequality: This metric captures disparities in income and wealth distribution within a population. Higher levels of inequality can limit access to financial services for lower-income groups, thereby constraining overall financial inclusion.

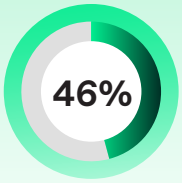
Real-time payments access: This metric assesses the availability of fast, secure payment systems. Financial inclusion extends beyond basic access to payments; users must also be able to transact efficiently and reliably through real-time payment networks.

Digital payments literacy gap: This metric measures the difference in digital payments adoption between individuals aged 16–24 and those aged 25 and above. A larger gap, regardless of direction, indicates uneven levels of awareness, skills, or trust in digital payment systems across age groups.

North America performs well across most metrics for financial inclusion, with one exception - access to real-time payments. The USA and Canada both launched their real-time 24/7 settlement system considerably later than their counterparts across the world. FedNow launched in the US in 2023, while Canada's Real-time Rail - announced a decade ago - is scheduled for launch in the latter half of 2026. This late launch is due to a myriad of factors; the most prominent being the need to accommodate legacy banking systems, which hampers interoperability. For example, the planned real-time rail in Canada requires all payments to be routed through the for-profit legacy system Interac eTransfer, which does not support the ISO 20022 messaging standard.

Latin America has made significant steps towards improving financial inclusion over the past decade; achieving 70% of the population within the financial system in 2025, up from 50% in 2017.[3] However, a digital payments literacy gap is still prevalent across Latin America, as Gen Z were far more likely to have made digital payments in the past three months, compared to their older counterparts.[4] This suggests that access to digital payments is being rolled out inequitably across the population, with not enough investment in providing those who are older with accessible methods of converting their everyday payment methods into digital ones - for example, uploading their physical card to a digital wallet. This leaves them without methods of accessing eCommerce, paying bills online, or sending international money transfer digitally; financially excluding them from certain activities.

Amongst 18–24-year-olds in Brazil



save money using a digital wallet

The Digital Banking Wave: Saving & Accessing Credit

Compared to all surveyed countries, those in the US were most likely to report that they do not save or borrow money. This, combined with the survey finding that one in four respondents save via cash kept at home, suggests a significant issue with underbanking in the US. This reflects a combination of high living costs, lower household savings buffers, and a greater reliance on alternative financial instruments such as credit cards. Lack of trust in the formal banking system is another factor; suggesting that payment service providers trying to bridge this gap should prioritise security and real-time tracking of payments to maximise transparency.

For those who do save money, a bank account is the most common method. However, a clear divergence emerges with mobile money and digital wallet use. In Brazil, 40% save money using a mobile wallet account, which rises to 46% in those 18-24; indicating higher digital engagement amongst the youth. In comparison, less than half that proportion save money this way in the US, instead using pass-through digital wallets to make merchant transactions rather than as savings.

[3] Reimagining the Future of Finance in Latin America and the Caribbean — IDB Invest
[4] The Global Findex Database 2025 — World Bank

Figure 1.4: Method of Saving or Accessing Credit (% of respondents, multiple choice)

Method of Saving & Accessing Credit	US	Brazil
Bank savings account in the resident country	53%	60%
Bank savings account in non-resident country	7%	6%
Money saved in a mobile money account or digital wallet in the resident country	17%	40%
Money saved in a mobile money account or digital wallet in non-resident country	6%	10%
Cash savings kept at home	25%	14%
Informal lenders (friends, family, community members)	5%	4%
Formal loans from banks or other financial institutions	8%	15%
Buy Now, Pay Later (BNPL) services	9%	3%
Credit from shops or merchants	7%	9%
I do not save money	15%	8%
I do not borrow money	15%	6%



The most common entry into the formal financial system is through a traditional bank account, which holds true across the globe. However, significant differences emerge when viewing through the lens of age. In the Americas, amongst those 65 and over, 94% opened a bank account as their first formal financial account. This dominance of the conventional banking system drops with age; reaching 38% in those 18-24. In this age group, digital banks have outperformed traditional ones for the first time, as 42% opened a digital bank account.

In the US and Brazil, 18–24-year-olds are more likely to open a bank account because' it was recommended' compared to their older counterparts, while this drops to 14% for those 25 and above. Competition in the banking industry is also positively increasing choice for users; 28% of those 65 chose their first account because it was 'the only one accessible', while this dropped to 18% in those 18-24-year-olds.

1.4.3 Cross-Border Connectivity

Country	Cross-Border Connectivity
Canada	6.3
US	5.9
Brazil	3.6
Chile	3.0
Argentina	3.0
Peru	3.0
Mexico	3.8
Colombia	3.5

The cross-border connectivity metric measures the ease, speed, and price of making cross-border payments, as well as the value of cross-border payments made.

The criteria considered when measuring the connectivity of cross-border payments are:

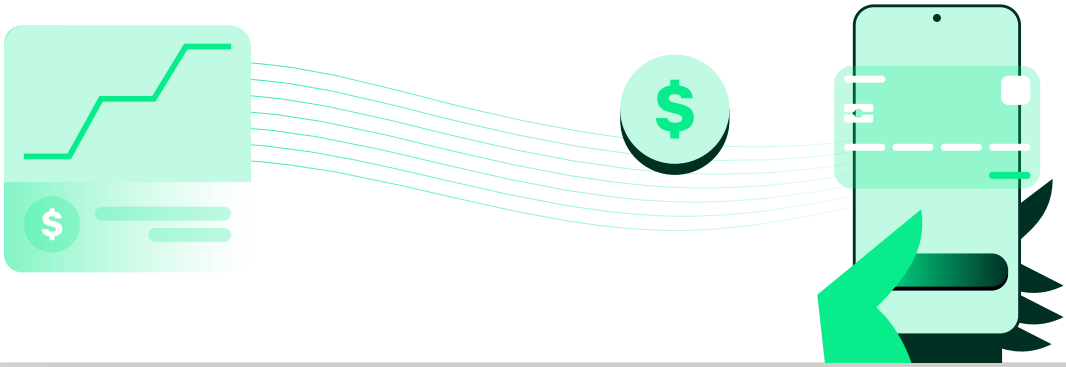
Remittance costs: This measures the cost of making P2P payments across borders, as measured by the World Bank. This covers banks, money transfer operators, and post office cash transfers.

Cross-border value: This measures the value of cross-border payments per capita in 2025.

Cross-border instant payments penetration: his measures the proportion of cross-border payments made via instant payment or fast payment schemes.

The US is the largest remittance-sending country in terms of total value, although a small proportion of the total population send remittances. Only 7.8% of survey respondents in the US sent money, whereas in countries such as Saudi Arabia, the proportion reaches 40%. This, as well as the considerable number of payments companies based in America, means that the USA is often prioritised as a cross-border route. Most countries have direct banking relationships with counterparts in the USA; minimising the third-party fees necessary.

In comparison, Latin America is a less popular location to send and receive both international P2P and B2B payments; resulting in lower connectivity within the international payments ecosystem.



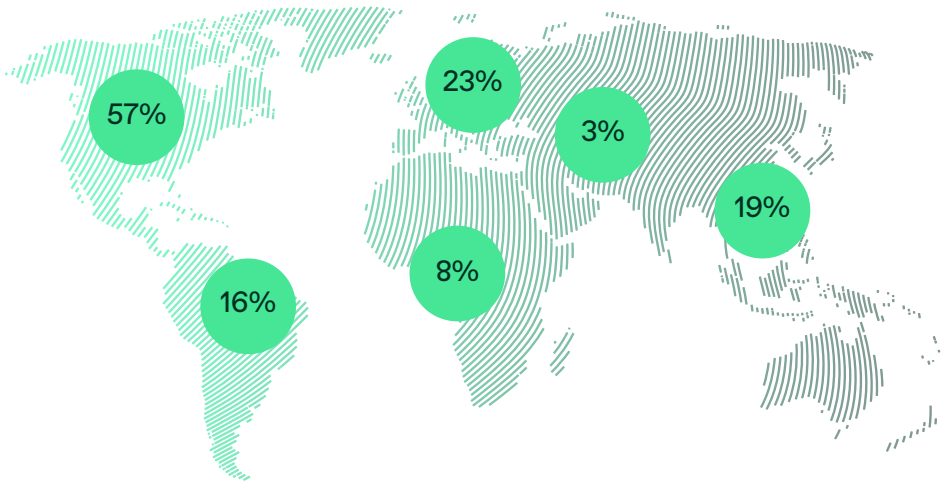
Corridor View of Payments: The Americas

a) Sending International Payments

A minority of survey respondents reported that they had sent international payments in the past year: 16.4% of those in the US and 19.6% of those in Brazil had sent payments in the last 12 months.

The most common location that both those in the US and Brazil send international payments to is North America. In Brazil, Europe was the second most common destination for international payments, as 34% of Brazilians sending money sent it to Europe. In the US, Asia was the second most common destination, as 25% sent money there in the past year.

Figure 1.5: Destinations for Payments Originating from the US and Brazil (% of those sending international payments, multiple choice)



Remittances were the most common reason for people to be sending money overseas. In the US, eCommerce purposes such as paying for goods overseas was the second most common purpose, while in Brazil, overseas investment and saving was the next most prevalent reason.

Figure 1.6: Purpose for Sending Money (% of International Money Transferers, Multiple Choice)

Purpose for Sending Money	US	Brazil
Remittances	48%	41%
Paying for goods purchased overseas	35%	26%
Sending money to myself (for payments in another country)	25%	16%

cont'd

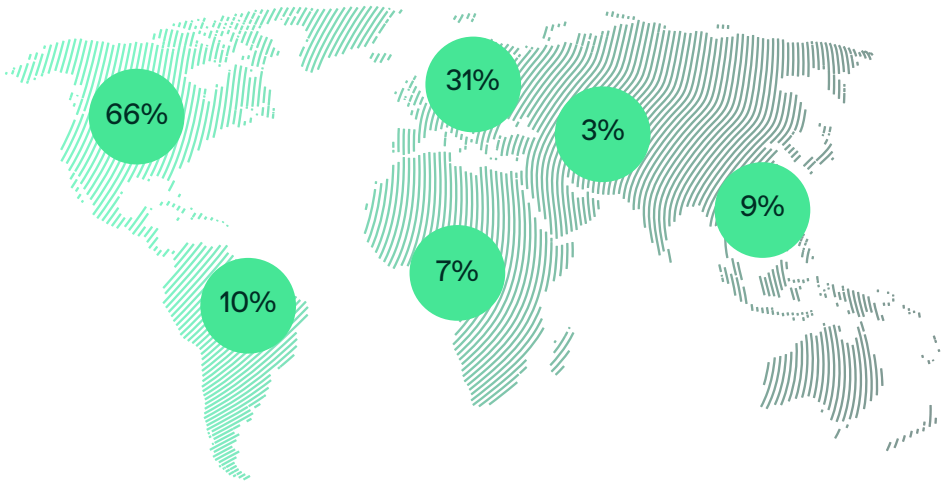
Purpose for Sending Money	US	Brazil
Sending money to myself	25%	24%
Investment or saving purposes	13%	35%
Sending a financial gift	9%	4%
Other	1%	1%

b) Receiving International Payments

Receiving money internationally is far more common in Brazil than the US. In the US, 13.5% of those surveyed had received money internationally in the past year, while in Brazil this was 42.5%.

The most common location for those in the US and Brazil to receive money from is from North America, followed by Europe.

Figure 1.7: Originating Regions of Payments Made to the US and Brazil (% of those receiving international payments, multiple choice)



Those in the US were less likely to be receiving payments from overseas employers than those in other countries. Globally, 10.2% of respondents received payment from an overseas employer, but this prevalence was only 2.4% in the US.

The most common reason to be receiving international payments in the US is for remittance purposes, with payments for selling goods as the second reason. In Brazil, receiving a salary from an overseas employer was the most frequent reason to be receiving international payments.

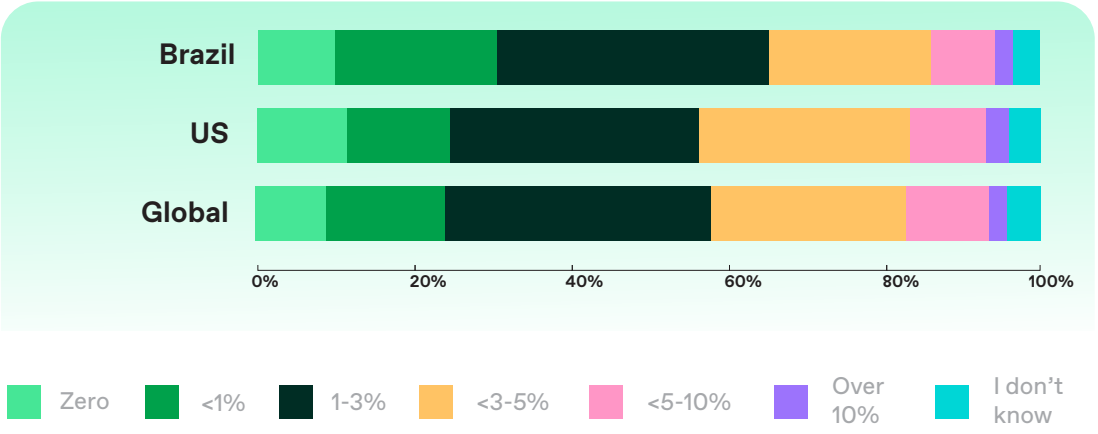
Figure 1.8: Purpose for Receiving Payment (% of those Receiving International Payments, Multiple Choice)

Purpose for Receiving Money	US	Brazil
Salary or payment from an overseas employer	18%	31%
Payment for goods sold	36%	12%
Refund or reimbursement	27%	7%
Money sent by family or friends (personal remittance)	39%	23%
Money sent by me (for payments to be made in another country)	20%	14%
Investment income (e.g. dividends, interest)	14%	24%
Financial support or gifts	15%	2%

c) The Cost of Cross-Border Payments

Brazil experiences one of the highest incidences of fees across all surveyed countries, while the US experiences fees largely in line with the global average. This is likely due to the lack of direct connections from the rest of the world to Latin America, whilst North America is often prioritised as a cross-border corridor, due to the high volume of remittances flowing to and from the region.

Figure 1.9: Typical Cost of Sending a Cross-Border Payment (by % of those sending international payments)



However, the financially vulnerable face higher costs when sending money overseas. One in three (33%) of those with no reported financial vulnerabilities reported that they typically pay fees of 3% or over when making a cross-border transaction. This rose to 47% for those in the US and Brazil who stated that they 'sometimes do not have enough income to cover living expenses'. As the UN has set a goal of reducing fees to 3% or less to preserve the purchasing capacity of migrant families, this indicates that almost half are paying too much in fees.

1.4.4 Market Dynamics and Progress

Country	Market Dynamics & Progress
Brazil	10.0
Mexico	7.5
Chile	6.0
US	5.0
Colombia	5.0
Argentina	4.5
Canada	4.0
Peru	4.0

The market dynamics and progress score indicates the industry momentum behind cross-border initiatives in the market. In order to assess the regulatory environment and engagement in cross-border projects, this metric was assessed by:

Cross-border payment growth: This is based on a forecast of the percentage growth a market will experience in the next four years.

Cryptocurrency regulation status: This assesses the openness of the market towards cryptocurrencies as payment instruments, based on the existence of regulatory clarity towards this technology.

Open banking mandates: This assesses the existence and prevalence of open banking connections in a market, based on the level of adoption by banks and consumers and regulations mandating open banking API availability.

Government-led initiatives: This appraises the participation of a country's central bank in cross-border interoperability initiatives, including regulatory roadmaps, pilot participation, fast payment system linkage, and usage of common messaging standards.

Openness towards cross-border payments innovations and government investment in interoperability improvements varies across the region. Most countries are prioritising domestic interoperability before moving to cross-border interoperability. For example, Mexico is focusing on promoting the CoDi system, which allows anyone to make wire transfers quickly and cheaply with participating banks. In August 2026, Mexico launched a programme to encourage the use of CoDI domestically; demonstrating that investment is directed towards domestic use cases.



Cryptocurrency has considerable potential to disrupt remittances in Latin America and the Caribbean. As an area affected by correspondent 'de-risking' practices, remitters face being cut off from making international payments if a correspondent bank decides that AML obligations are too difficult to carry out in a region. Regions that are not cut off but still considered high risk may be subject to high fees for carry out AML and KYC checks. Many people in high-inflation environments or experiencing currency volatility may have already entered the stablecoin space as it holds its own store of value, so this familiarity helps transition towards using them for international payments.

The Development of PIX

Launched in 2020, PIX is the national instant transfer system of Brazil. The innovation of this development, combined with its popularity and ubiquity of use, has driven Brazil's high scores in the market dynamics category. PIX has enabled the majority of P2P, B2B, and C2B payments across Brazil to become instant, low-cost, and available 24/7. This has expanded access to digital payments and has significantly increased financial inclusion, as it only requires a smartphone to transfer money.

This has kicked off similar initiatives across the region to expand instant payment systems from P2P transfers towards merchant payments. For example, Colombia's Bre-B instant payment network was explicitly modelled on PIX. Argentina also launched their Transferencias 3.0 in December 2020, as part of a regional wave of central-bank instant payment rail launches.

What is missing so far is the regional integration of these systems. Payment systems remain relatively siloed from each other. While PIX is expanding out of Brazil, it has taken an approach of commercial integration; allowing merchants in other countries such as Uruguay and Argentina to accept PIX at checkout so Brazilian tourists can transact in a familiar manner. This type of interoperability remains closed-loop and does not encompass the true bilateral links between regional payment systems, whereby a user of PIX would be able to transfer to the Bre-B or Yape system. This leaves users reliant on specialist money transfer operators to bridge this gap.

Engagement in Cross-Border Initiatives

The Bank of Mexico and the Federal Reserve of New York are both part of Project Agora, which explores how the tokenisation of wholesale central bank money and commercial bank deposits could improve the speed and cost of international payments. This conducted real value testing in July 2026, where 28 financial institutions and central banks across Asia, Europe, North America completed

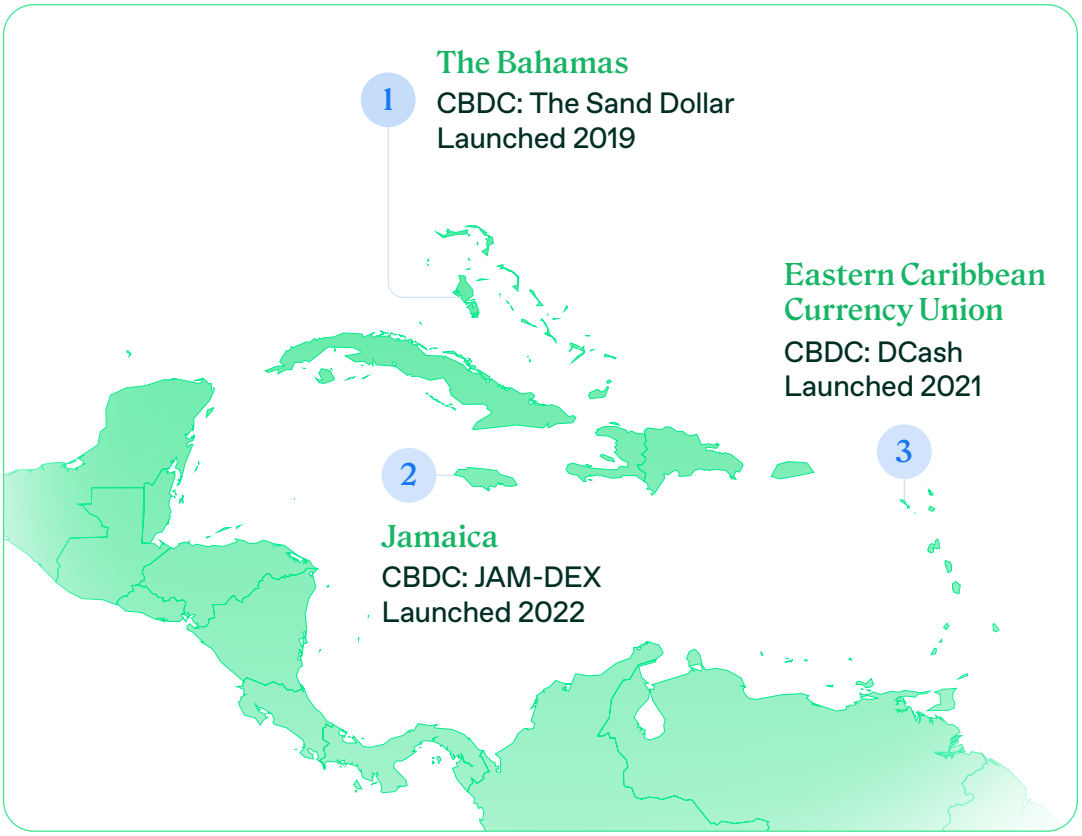
transactions in a selection of currencies; demonstrating the feasibility of settling real-value transactions on a multi-currency programmable ledger.

Another major regional initiative is the CARICOM Payments and Settlement System (CAPSS),; a pilot project designed to allow B2B payments to occur across the Caribbean in local currencies without routing through a US correspondent bank account and picking up fees and delays. In July 2026, it was announced that this system is in active pilot. This is expected to lower transfer costs across the region.

Central Bank Digital Currency Progress

Three of the four currently live CBDCs are located in the Caribbean, which is a result of the need for digital payment methods in a cash-resilient economy, as well as the uneven coverage of cash financial services across the Archipelagos.

Figure 1.10: The Caribbean - Live CBDCs



The Bahamas launched the world's first CBDC - the Sand Dollar, a retail payment mechanism - in October 2020. This has offline payment capability and transaction limits, and aimed at providing a safe method of payment for individuals and small businesses. After three years, it had only gained a market share of 0.5% of cash in circulation.

Jamaica has launched JAM-DEX, their retail CBDC, in 2022. This has recorded considerable growth, and in March 2026, the Bank of Jamaica reported that the JAM-DEX transaction value was up 550% in 2025; compared with 2024.

The Eastern Caribbean Currency Union launched DCash, which has been live in four member states since March 2021. Amid a two-month blackout due to certificate expiration and low adoption, the ECCU has pivoted towards providing Fast Payment System bank transfers instead.

This divergence of national currencies fragments payments further, and complicates interoperability initiatives, as they are limited by their national borders and only available to member citizens. However, uptake has been very low across most retail CBDCs apart from Jamaica; indicating that improving interoperability amongst existing payment systems is more important to citizens than developing new payment ecosystems. This is echoed across the region. The US banned a national CBDC in February 2025, and Canada similarly scaled back plans for a CBDC in December 2024; stating that their focus groups felt well-served by existing forms of payments.

Stablecoins

Stablecoins - cryptocurrencies pegged to the value of a fiat currency - do not hold a prominent position in the cross-border ecosystem of US and Brazil. Despite the US holding a prominent global position as a hub for cryptocurrency development, the proportion of people using it is comparatively small. According to the survey, 12% of those in the US use stablecoins, with a further 17% interested in using them, which is higher than European respondents, but lower than those in the Middle East, Africa, and Asia.

Only 10% of those sending cross-border payments in the US and 12% of those in Brazil use a cryptocurrency platform, which is line with the global average of 11%. This indicates that usage is concentrated in a small segment of the population, and has not yet spread to encompass considerable cross-border usage.

Figure 1.11: Usage of Stablecoins (% of respondents)

Usage of Stablecoins	US	Brazil
I already use them	12%	13%
I do not use stablecoins but am interested in using them	10%	30%
I would like to use stablecoins but am restricted from doing so	7%	6%

cont'd

Usage of Stablecoins	US	Brazil
I have not heard of stablecoins	48%	41%
I know of stablecoins but am not interested in using them for payments	23%	10%

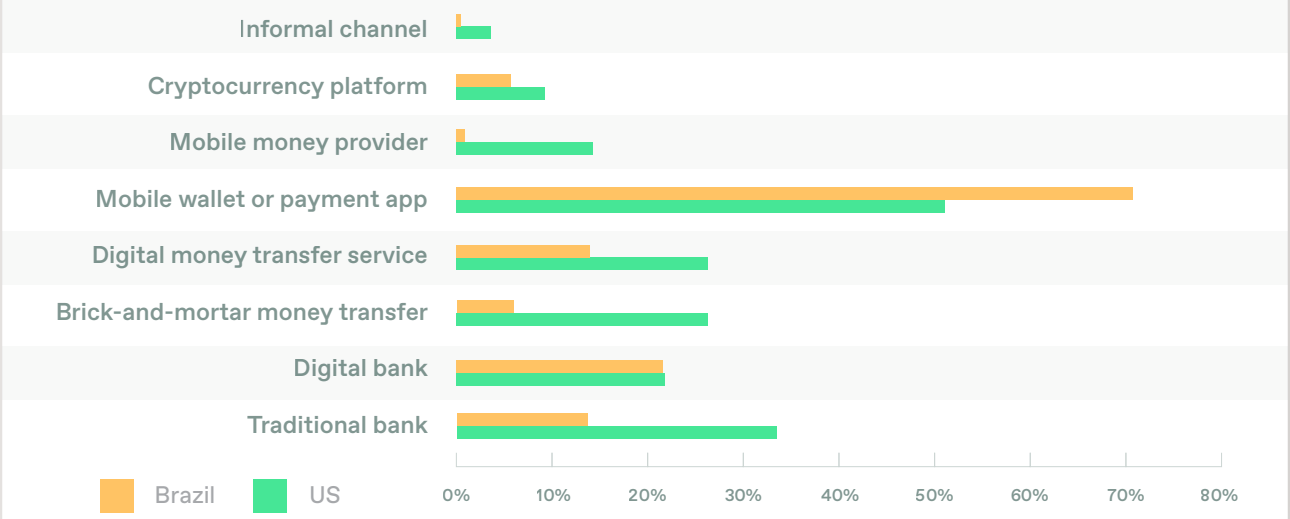
There is a substantial proportion of the US proportion who state that they 'would not use stablecoins for international payments for any reason': 36%, triple the global average of 12% and lower than Brazil at 5%. This likely links to satisfaction with their current payment methods: 35% of those in the US stated that a factor preventing them from using stablecoins is that 'I am happy with my current payment methods', which drives a lack of need to diversify their payments behaviours into new systems such as stablecoins.

As a result, those providing international payments services in the US should prioritise improving interoperability with existing payment methods, as the current impetus for stablecoins is low. Although it may improve in the future when familiarity increases. Instead, emerging markets such as Brazil present the largest current opportunity for stablecoin usage, as they currently struggle with long wait times and high costs for international payments.

1.4.5 Payment Provider Preferences

Globally, the primary type of payments provider used to receive money internationally is a mobile wallet; a pattern replicated in both the US and Brazil. This preference emerges particularly strongly in Brazil, where 71% of those receiving international payments report that they typically do so via a mobile wallet or payment app.

Figure 1.12: Payment Provider Used (% of those receiving money internationally, multiple choice)

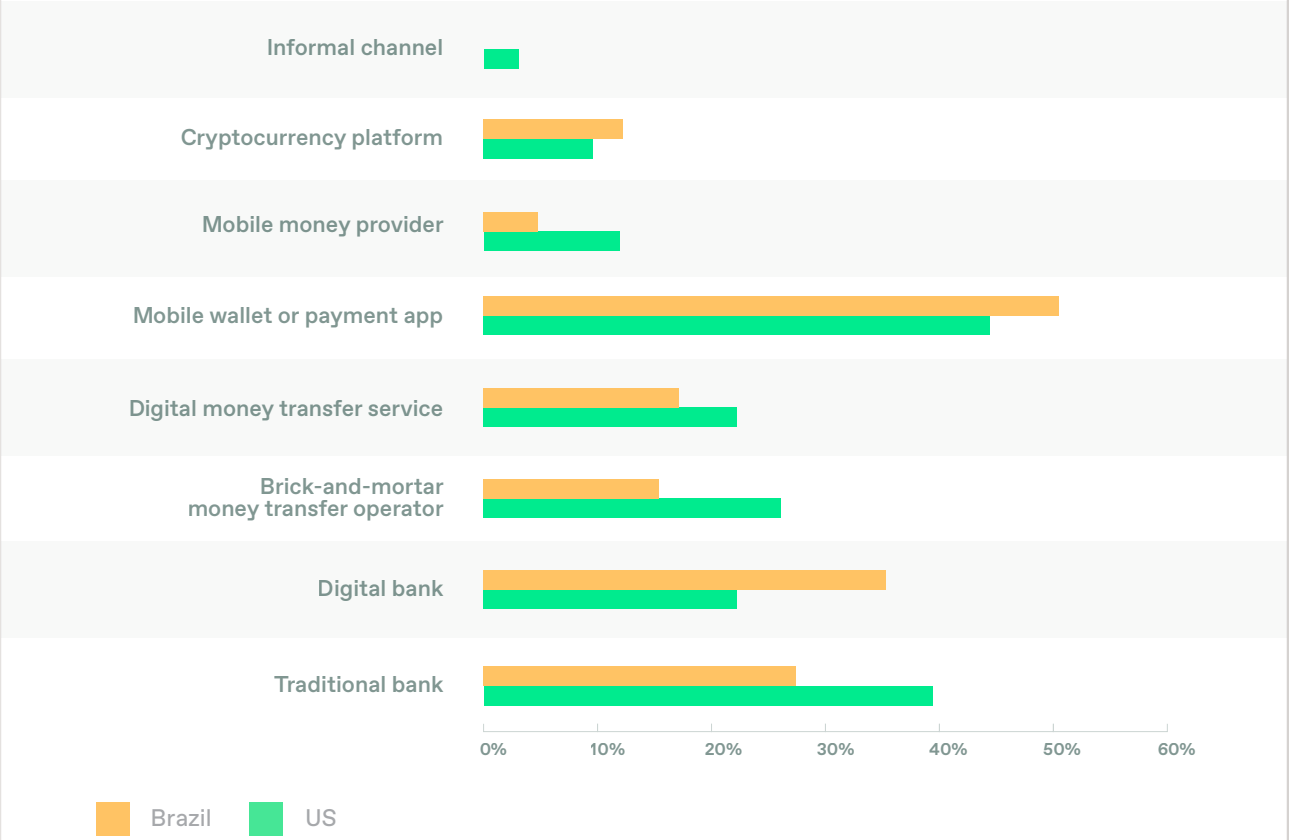


Sending Money

In both the US and Brazil, mobile wallets and payment apps are the preferred mechanism for transferring money, which is in line with global preferences.

Traditional methods such as banks and brick-and-mortar money transfer operators have fallen out of favour in Brazil, likely due to difficulties with the correspondent banking systems. However, use of traditional banks remains strong in US as the second most favoured option.

Figure 1.13: Payment Provider Used to Send Money (% of those sending money internationally, multiple choice)



Resilience of Cash in the US

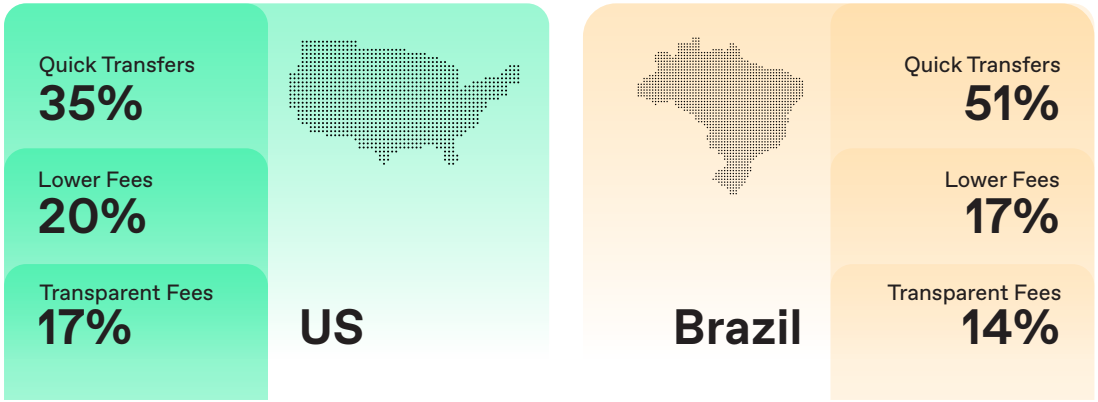
The US stands out as the country most likely to fund international transactions with cash. While only 6% of international payment senders fund their payments with cash, this rises to 20% amongst those in the US. This indicates the necessity for international payment providers to maintain connections with agent locations for users to pay cash to, even in markets with high digital payments usage such as the US.

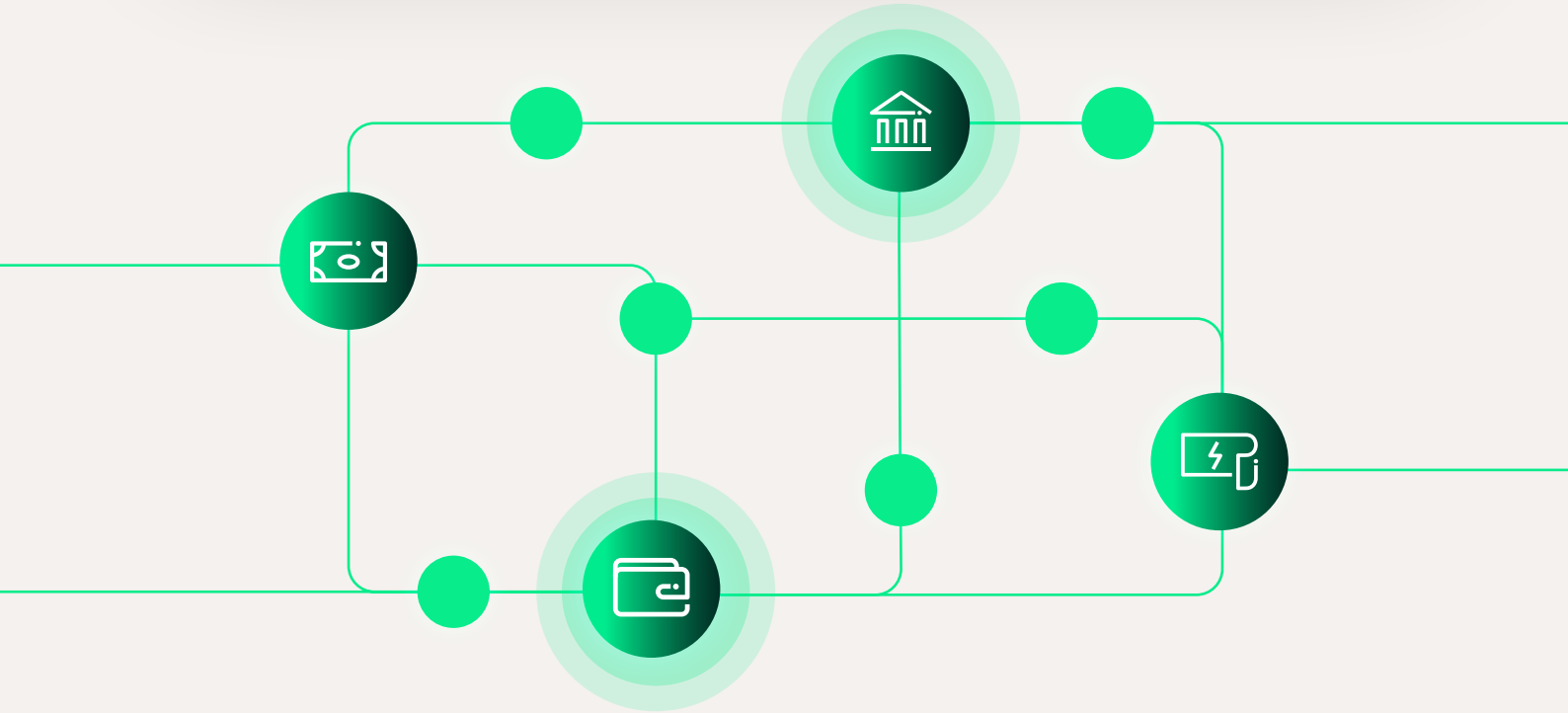
Competitive Differentiators

A speedy transfer is the most valued characteristic of the international payments service provider that respondents typically use; emphasising the importance of speed in user choice. This was more important than characteristics such as low fees, security, convenience, habit, and recommendations from friends and family.

Notably, only 3% of those in the US, and no respondents in Brazil reported that they chose their payments provider because there was no other one available; suggesting that there is a healthy level of competition in the region.

Figure 1.14: Top Ranked Priorities in a Payments Provider (% of those sending international payments)





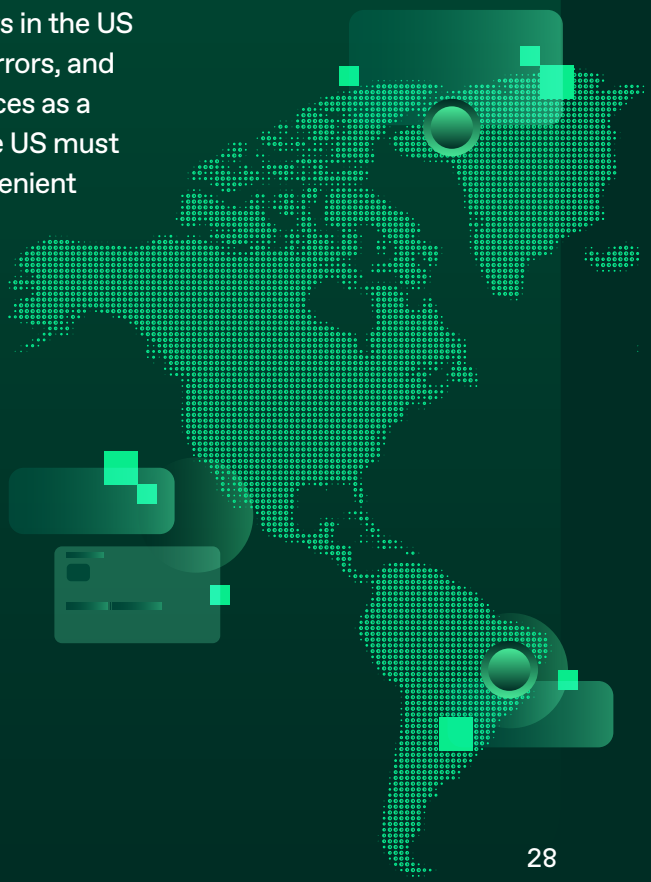
1.4.6 Conclusion

Digital payments are proliferating across the Americas, from the popularity of pass-through wallets in the US to mobile payments in Peru and A2A payments in Brazil. However, while countries such as Brazil are trailblazers in the field of payment innovations, this does not insulate them against poor international payment experiences. Despite their widely used A2A payments platform PIX making low-cost instant payments widely available across the population, the lack of bilateral links to other regional payment systems means that those seeking to send money internationally still face disproportionately long waits and high costs.

Overall, the Americas lag behind other regions in terms of establishing bilateral links to real-time gross settlement systems and fast payment systems. The EU and Asia have both made considerable progress with this. The EU has its TARGET interlinking framework, while Thailand, Hong Kong, Singapore, and Malaysia have all made various bilateral arrangements. In comparison, North America and Latin America have not formed similar regional initiatives. This leaves commercial providers to bridge the gaps left by a lack of centralised connections.

This survey's findings have exposed the strong wave of digital banking sweeping Latin America. This is increasing digital financial inclusion in the region, as well as influencing international payment preferences, as use of digital banks for sending cross-border payments now outweighs traditional banks. As a result, creating interoperability through partnerships with prominent digital banks is key for reaching the Latin American population; particularly Gen Z.

One of the major findings of the report is that users in the US are highly sensitive to payment delays, fees, and errors, and are more dissatisfied with their payment experiences as a result. International payment providers serving the US must take into account that a few experiences of inconvenient payment processes or slow payments can create a lasting effect on brand perception. Accordingly, reliability and consistency in service provision is key for satisfying the US market.



Looking ahead, those seeking to improve cross-border interoperability must focus on connecting to real-time local rails and directly to end-point accounts; meeting user demand for quick transfers.

The Interoperability Index Full Version

2

2.1 The Thunes Payments Interoperability Index, Full Version

Below is the full Interoperability Index, with scoring for each category outlined.

#	Country	Region	Economic Health	Digital Infra-structure Access	Financial Inclusion	Cross-Border Connect-ivity	Market Dynamics & Progress	Overall
1	Denmark	West Europe	8.8	9.5	9.5	8.9	6.0	**8.8**
2	Singapore	Rest of Asia Pacific	7.8	9.0	7.6	6.9	10.0	**8.3**
3	Norway	West Europe	8.5	8.8	7.9	9.2	6.5	**8.2**
4	Spain	West Europe	5.8	8.3	9.2	7.3	7.5	**8.0**
5	Nether-lands	West Europe	8.0	7.8	9.1	7.6	6.5	**8.0**
6	Sweden	West Europe	7.8	8.5	8.4	6.6	7.5	**8.0**
7	UK	West Europe	6.8	7.5	8.7	7.6	8.0	**7.9**
8	Switzer-land	West Europe	7.8	7.5	8.2	8.3	6.5	**7.7**
9	Austria	West Europe	6.8	7.8	7.4	8.6	7.0	**7.6**
10	Australia	Rest of Asia Pacific	7.0	7.5	7.1	7.6	8.5	**7.5**
11	Finland	West Europe	7.0	7.0	7.6	8.6	7.0	**7.4**
12	Germany	West Europe	7.0	8.0	6.5	7.3	7.5	**7.3**
13	South Korea	Far East & China	7.0	9.0	6.8	5.0	7.0	**7.2**
14	Belgium	West Europe	7.8	7.3	7.3	7.9	6.0	**7.2**
15	France	West Europe	7.0	5.8	8.0	7.9	7.5	**7.1**
16	Ireland	West Europe	8.8	5.8	7.5	7.9	6.0	**6.9**

#	Country	Region	Economic Health	Digital Infra-structure Access	Financial Inclusion	Cross-Border Connect-ivity	Market Dynamics & Progress	Overall
17	Japan	Far East & China	5.0	8.0	6.7	6.9	6.5	**6.9**
18	Portugal	West Europe	5.3	7.0	6.3	7.6	6.5	**6.6**
19	Poland	Central & East Europe	4.8	6.8	6.9	5.9	7.5	**6.6**
20	Italy	West Europe	6.3	7.5	4.9	7.9	7.0	**6.6**
21	US	North America	6.8	7.5	6.6	5.9	5.0	**6.5**
22	Canada	North America	7.5	7.0	6.7	6.3	4.0	**6.4**
23	China	Far East & China	3.3	6.5	6.8	7.3	5.0	**6.2**
24	Brazil	Latin America	2.5	6.0	6.4	3.6	10.0	**6.0**
25	Hungary	Central & East Europe	5.5	5.3	6.7	6.6	5.5	**6.0**
26	Croatia	Central & East Europe	5.3	5.8	5.7	7.6	5.5	**5.9**
27	New Zealand	Rest of Asia Pacific	6.8	6.3	5.3	6.3	5.5	**5.9**
28	Malaysia	Rest of Asia Pacific	4.0	6.0	6.1	5.0	7.0	**5.8**
29	Thailand	Rest of Asia Pacific	3.5	4.8	6.5	5.3	7.5	**5.6**
30	India	Indian Sub-continent	1.3	2.5	7.3	6.9	9.0	**5.5**
31	United Arab Emirates	Middle East	6.8	5.3	5.2	5.3	5.5	**5.4**
32	Saudi Arabia	Middle East	4.5	5.0	4.9	4.3	5.5	**4.9**
33	Mexico	Latin America	4.0	3.3	5.7	2.6	7.5	**4.6**

#	Country	Region	Economic Health	Digital Infra-structure Access	Financial Inclusion	Cross-Border Connect-ivity	Market Dynamics & Progress	Overall
34	Chile	Latin America	4.8	4.3	4.4	3.0	6.0	**4.4**
35	Kuwait	Middle East	8.0	4.3	3.3	4.6	3.5	**4.3**
36	Kenya	Africa	1.3	3.3	5.9	1.7	7.5	**4.2**
37	Indonesia	Rest of Asia Pacific	2.0	3.0	4.1	5.9	6.0	**4.1**
38	Turkey	Central & East Europe	4.0	4.3	5.0	2.3	3.0	**4.0**
39	Argentina	Latin America	3.3	3.8	4.5	3.0	4.5	**3.9**
40	Vietnam	Rest of Asia Pacific	2.8	3.5	4.1	3.6	5.0	**3.8**
41	Qatar	Middle East	5.5	4.8	2.9	3.0	3.5	**3.8**
42	Philippines	Rest of Asia Pacific	2.0	2.8	3.3	4.3	7.5	**3.8**
43	Nigeria	Africa	3.3	2.5	5.0	1.3	5.5	**3.6**
44	South Africa	Africa	3.3	2.5	4.1	3.0	5.5	**3.6**
45	Colombia	Latin America	3.3	3.0	3.5	2.6	5.0	**3.4**
46	Peru	Latin America	4.5	1.8	3.8	3.0	4.0	**3.2**
47	Egypt	Africa	2.5	1.8	3.8	1.7	5.5	**3.0**
48	Bangla-desh	Indian Sub-continent	2.5	1.3	4.3	1.0	4.5	**2.7**
49	Nepal	Indian Sub-continent	1.3	1.8	4.6	0.7	4.0	**2.7**
50	Pakistan	Indian Sub-continent	0.8	1.3	4.6	0.7	5.0	**2.7**

Appendix

3

3.1 Survey Methodology

i. Geographic and Household Income Coverage

The survey recruited respondents online, including individuals who had experience sending money internationally as well as those who had not. Respondents represented a broad cross-section of people across income thresholds. The sample was designed to capture a range of perspectives on cross-border payments, including both active users and non-users of international money transfer services.

Fig. 3.1 Number of Respondents Recruited per Country

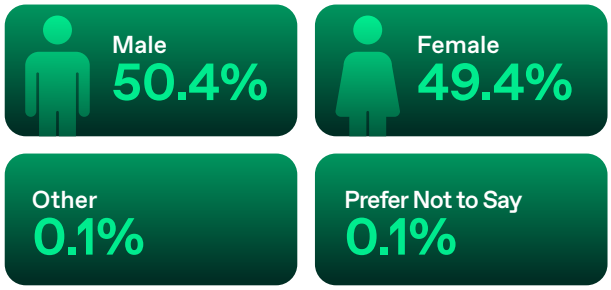
Country	Number of respondents
US	1,013
Brazil	541
Saudi Arabia	507
China	1,026
India	554
Philippines	527
UK	1,011
Germany	519
South Africa	516
Nigeria	549

ii. Sampling and Recruitment

Participants were recruited via online panels using pre-defined screening criteria to ensure respondents were located within the chosen countries. Screening questions were used to identify respondents based on their experience with sending and/or receiving international payments.

A balanced sample across key demographic groups was achieved:

Fig. 3.2 Survey Sample Demographics by Country



iii. Data Collection

The survey was conducted online using a structured questionnaire. A total of 6,763 completed responses met all screening criteria and quality checks and were included in the final analysis. Data collection took place over the period of April 2026.

iv. Survey Instrument

The questionnaire consisted of 44 questions and was designed to capture behaviours, preferences, and experiences related to cross-border payments. Participants were routed to one of four versions of the survey based on their responses to initial screening questions:

- Respondents who both sent and received international payments were shown the full survey.
- Respondents who neither sent nor received international payments were shown a shorter version consisting of 17 questions.
- Respondents who only sent or only received international payments were shown relevant sections tailored to their experience.

This routing approach ensured that questions remained relevant to each participant while minimising respondent burden.

Limitations
As with all survey-based research, the findings are subject to certain limitations:

- The survey was conducted online, which may exclude individuals without internet access or those less likely to participate in digital panels.
- Responses are self-reported and may be subject to recall bias or social desirability bias.
- Finally, as the survey was carried out in April 2026, the results capture responses at this point in time. Changes in economic conditions or regulations may affect consumer attitudes or experiences after this point.

3.2 Interoperability Index Methodology

The Payments Interoperability Index was developed to assess the accessibility and ease of making payments across borders. This was assessed via five core dimensions, designed to capture different aspects of interoperability. The dimensions are as follows:

Economic Health: This is designed to capture the macroeconomic environment of the countries, as well as the human and social experiences of living within this. This assessed measures including GDP, trade openness, volume of operating businesses and quality of life.

Digital Infrastructure: This measures how connected citizens are to the internet, as well as the proportion of the adult population who have made or received a digital payment in the past 3 months.

Financial Inclusion: This uses measures such as wealth inequality, access to bank branches, and the proportion of the adult population who have a formal financial account or mobile money account.

Cross-Border Connectivity: This measures factors such as the cost of sending and receiving remittances, the proportion of consumer transactions made via instant payment schemes, and the overall value of the cross-border payments market

Market Dynamics and Progress: This measures the progress of various regulatory and government mandates designed to improve the money transfer market, such as government-led initiatives, open banking mandates and cryptocurrency regulations. In order to assess the potential of the market, it also assesses the forecast growth in the market.

The score given in each dimension reflects a set of measurable indicators. These were sourced from a variety of reliable sources: for example, the Global Findex Database 2025, which is a demand-side survey of 145,000 adults in 141 economies. This provides data on how adults around the world use both formal and informal financial services to save, borrow, make payments, and manage financial risk.

Also used was World Bank data regarding remittance costs around the world. The World Bank releases quarterly releases with the SmaRT indicator the simple average of the three cheapest qualifying services for sending the equivalent of $200 in each country.

This aims to reflect what a savvy consumer with access to sufficiently complete information could pay to transfer remittances in each corridor. Services qualify if they make the payment in five days or less, as well as being accessible by geographic proximity (e.g. to branches) for services that require physical presence.

To ensure that the Interoperability Index represented a holistic view of market dynamics, a qualitative assessment of various metrics was conducted. This used central bank publications and government releases on national digital payment strategies to assess the openness of the market to technological shifts, such as the presence or absence of cryptocurrency regulations and participation in cross-border fast payment system linkage pilots.

Finally, in-house data regarding the value of cross-border payments and the proportion of payments made via instant payment schemes were utilised for the index. Further information on these can be found in the report Cross-border Payments Market 2026-2030.

About Thunes

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About

4.1

Thunes.

Thunes is the Smart Superhighway to move money around the world. Thunes' proprietary Direct Global Network allows Members to make payments in real-time in over 140 countries and more than 90 currencies. Thunes' Network connects directly to over 12 billion mobile wallets, stablecoin wallets and bank accounts worldwide, as well as 15 billion cards via more than 220 different payment methods, such as GCash, M-Pesa, Airtel, MTN, Orange, JazzCash, Easypaisa, AliPay, WeChat Pay and many more. Thunes' Direct Global Network differentiates itself through its worldwide reach, in-house SmartX Treasury System and Fortress Compliance Platform, ensuring Members of the Network receive unrivaled speed, control, visibility, protection, and cost efficiencies when making real-time payments, globally. Members of Thunes' Direct Global Network include gig economy giants like Uber and Deliveroo, super-apps like Grab and WeChat, MTOs, fintechs, PSPs and banks. Headquartered in Singapore, Thunes has offices in 14 locations, including New York, Barcelona, Beijing, Dubai, Hong Kong, Johannesburg, London, Manila, Nairobi, Paris, Riyadh, San Francisco and Shanghai. For more information, visit thunes.com.

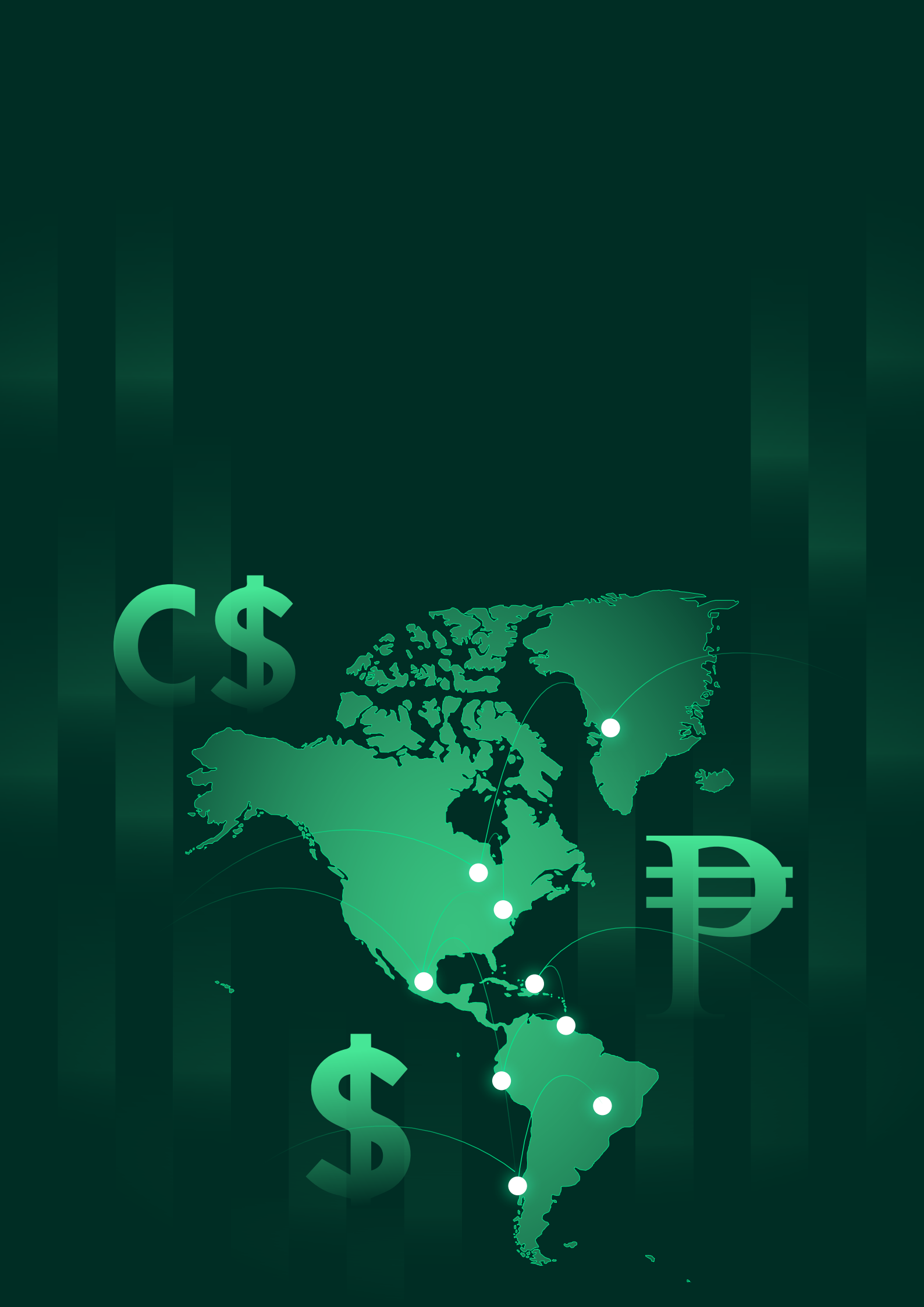
About

4.2

JUNIPER RESEARCH

Juniper Research is a global tech strategist firm providing research, data, and forecasting across the fintech, telecoms, and IoT sectors. For over 20 years, Juniper Research has delivered actionable insights; helping industry leaders navigate disruption, seize opportunities, and make confident strategic decisions. juniperresearch.com




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